

CHANGE: ZACCHAEUS

Before you read the story, you will need to teach the audience a few responses. Each time a word in bold type is read out, the audience respond with the relevant word/phrase.

Jesus: Hooray!

Zacchaeus: We don't like you!

Crowd: Mutter, mutter, mutter, mutter!

Tax collector: Ker-ching!

One spring day, over Jericho, the sun peeped through the collected clouds, eager to see... **Jesus**. Down below, lots of people had gathered too, for the same reason. The clouds sighed with joy when they saw **Jesus** creating a breeze which gently stirred the leaves on the trees to song. In one of those trees crouched a wee man called **Zacchaeus**. He wasn't tall enough to see over the **crowd** and the **crowd** wouldn't make way for him. You see, **Zacchaeus** was a **tax collector** and the **crowd** didn't like **tax collectors**, who often cheated to make themselves rich. So he had climbed all the way up to the top of a tree, with a lot of huffing and a lot of puffing, because he didn't want to miss a thing!

Zacchaeus really wanted to see **Jesus**, but he was just checking that no one could see up his robe as he sat in the tree, when someone surprised him by calling his name! '**Zacchaeus!** Come down. I want to come to your house today and eat with you.' **Zacchaeus** couldn't have got down much quicker if he'd fallen out of the tree! When he saw **Jesus** standing there, he smiled the biggest of big smiles, nodding as though his head were loose. 'That would be wonderful!' he said.

But the **crowd** didn't think it was wonderful. They began to mumble, moan and grumble: 'Fancy **Jesus** going to eat with someone like that! A sinner! How dreadful!' But **Jesus** let their words fall away like the sand from his shoes, because he saw what they couldn't see – he saw that **Zacchaeus** wasn't just hungry for dinner, he was hungry to get to know God.

And do you know what happened? When **Zacchaeus** welcomed **Jesus** into his home, he changed! (Zacc, that is) Yes, he really turned over a new leaf! How do I know? Because he chose to pay back the people he'd taken money from and, if he'd cheated them, to pay them back four times what he'd taken! Well! Isn't it amazing what a meeting with Jesus can do?

THANKFULNESS: THE HEALING OF THE BLIND MAN

Tell the children that you'd like them to help you tell the story. They will need to use their imaginations, their hands to make the sounds of footsteps and their voices to be the voice of the blind man when he shouts out. Practise shouting 'Jesus, please help me!'

THE STORY:

Imagine that you can't see. Close your eyes for a moment and think how it must be to live in a world of darkness.

Imagine that you are a blind man sitting on the ground where you sit every day, begging, because you haven't got any other way of making any money. Even when unkind people make fun of you, you still stay there because you hope that maybe one day things will get better.

This day started like every other day, but now... listen... you have very good hearing. You can hear distant chatter. It sounds like lots of people and they sound excited. You can hear footsteps, some quick, some slower, coming towards you.

(Open your eyes and make the sounds of the footsteps)

As they get closer you can hear the rustle of clothes and smell the smell of feet that have been travelling a long time and some that have trodden in donkey poo! **(Hold your noses)**

You can hear what the people are saying. They are excited because they're following Jesus of Nazareth! You have heard about Him! You've heard that He can make sick people better. This is your chance! You are determined to make it count, so you take a deep breath and shout as loudly as you can:

'Jesus, please help me!'

The people around Jesus are shocked and tell you to be quiet, but you are not going to give up easily, so you shout again, even louder:

'Jesus, please help me!'

And then, amazingly, Jesus asks his friends to bring you over to Him, which they do, and then He asks you what you want Him to do for you! So you explain that you want to be able to see and you beg once again:

'Jesus, please help me!'

As soon as Jesus says to you that your faith has made you better, you start to see light and colour and then to make out shapes. You can see!

Everybody starts thanking God and singing. They are so happy and you are the happiest of all. You skip down the road, amazed at all the wonderful things there are to see, following Jesus and singing.

Let's do some skippy footsteps. **(Skip, skip. Skip, skip)**

What do you think you might want to say to Jesus? (I think 'thank you' is an excellent idea!)

Let's use our big voices again and shout together:

'Thank you, Jesus!'

FESTIVALS: EASTER MORNING

Tell the children you would like them to be involved in telling this story with you, by joining in at certain points. Instruct them that when they hear you say they couldn't believe their eyes/ears, they should respond 'Oh wow!' Tell them to listen for clues as to how they should say it – it won't be the same every time. The story is told from the point of view of one of the unnamed women from Luke's account of the resurrection.

A group of women walked quite slowly to the tomb very early that Sunday morning. Partly because they were so tired – they'd hardly slept the night before – and partly because they didn't really want to arrive at the tomb and see Jesus' dead body. But they wanted to honour Him by anointing Him with spices, just as Jewish traditions demanded, so they kept on going. It was Mary Magdalene who said, 'How will we move the stone away from the tomb? We're not strong enough and the guards certainly won't help us!' Nobody had an answer, but they just kept on walking anyway.

Just as the women arrived, the ground began to shake beneath their feet. They held on tightly to the jars of ointment so they wouldn't fall and break. Then the other Mary looked towards the tomb and she could hardly believe her eyes as she gasped:

'Oh wow!'

The great big stone had been rolled away and sitting on it was a glowing white angel!

All the women shook with fright, but the angel said: 'Don't be afraid! I know you're looking for Jesus, but He's not here. He has risen! Go and tell His disciples to go to Galilee and He'll meet them there.'

As the angel told them this amazing news, they couldn't believe their ears, and hesitatingly mumbled:

'Oh wow!'

Still a little afraid, but also very happy, they ran back to town to tell the men what had happened. It was then that they saw Him! Jesus! Alive! They couldn't believe their eyes! They shrieked with excitement:

'Oh wow!'

They ran towards Jesus, wanting to hug Him, but He just smiled and said: 'Don't be scared any longer. Just go and tell all my friends what the angel told you.'

So that's what they did. At first, the men didn't believe what the women told them. They wanted to see Jesus for themselves, and later that day, when they did, they couldn't believe their eyes. Very quietly, as the truth sank in, they murmured:

'Oh wow!'

One of the group, Thomas, wasn't there when they met Jesus, and when the others told him what had happened, he didn't believe it either! He said he needed to see and feel the scars on Jesus' hands and feet before he would believe.

A week later, Jesus did appear again, this time with Thomas there, and Jesus let him feel His hands and feet. Thomas couldn't believe his eyes, and he believed as he exclaimed:

'Oh wow!'